

FOOD

Chinese people take great pleasure in their food, which varies from region to region. Western cuisine from Sichuan province uses spices, while northern cuisine from Beijing is famous for its tasty roast duck. Cantonese food from the south is renowned across the world for its fish dishes and delicate flavors. Meals are cooked by steaming or stir-frying in a large pan called a wok. Rice is served in the south of the country, wheat buns or noodles in the north. The food is held in small bowls and chopsticks are used for eating.



Bean sprouts



Green mung beans are eaten as a dessert or candy.



Native to China, star anise is a spice that has a similar flavor to aniseed.



Ginger root adds a fresh, spicy taste to many dishes in western China.



Chili peppers are added to make hot, spicy dishes.

Rice, whether boiled, steamed, or fried, forms the basis of many Chinese dishes.

China bowl



Tea is served in handleless cups.

Tea, made without milk or sugar, is the most popular drink in China.



Jasmine tea is a light, refreshing drink made from green leaves. Black and Oolong are other types of Chinese tea.

Chopsticks are used for eating.

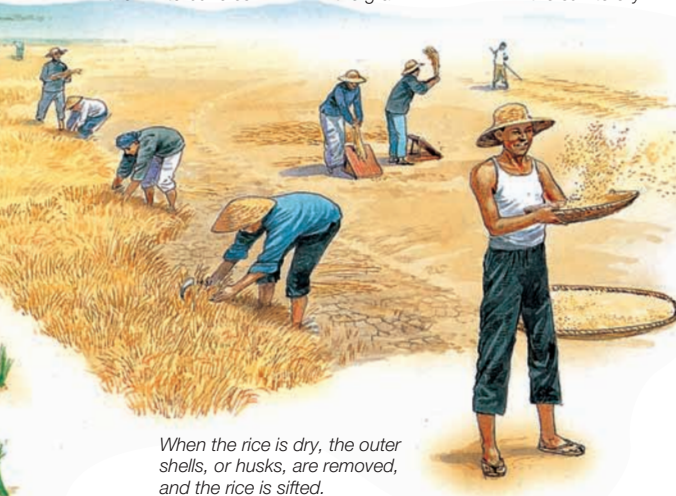
Knives are not needed because food is sliced before cooking.

Harvesting

Farmers cut the stalks with sickles and tie them into bundles.

The rice stalks are beaten to shake off the grain.

Piles of rice grains are left in the sun to dry.



When the rice is dry, the outer shells, or husks, are removed, and the rice is sifted.

CITY LIFE

About 500 million Chinese people live in towns and cities, many of which are overcrowded. Accommodations are scarce, and families usually live in one or two rooms rented from the company they work for. The city streets are full of bicycles, and public transportation, while cheap and frequent, is always packed. The main industrial and commercial city is Shanghai, home to 17 million people and one of the biggest cities in the world.



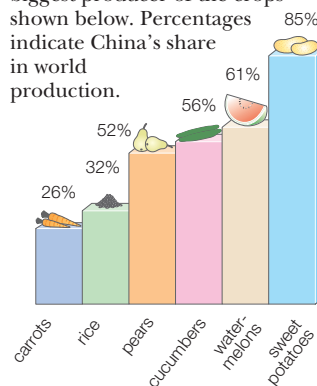
ONE-CHILD FAMILIES

The Chinese population is growing by about 9 million people a year, which is around the total population of Sweden. In order to reduce this rapid growth, the government introduced a policy in 1979 to limit each family to one child only. The single children are known as "Little Emperors" because they are often spoiled. The one-child policy has succeeded in the towns, but not in the country, where large families are needed to provide labor in the fields.



FOOD PRODUCTION

Every patch of fertile soil in China is used for agriculture. Crops are planted alongside roads and railroad tracks, and one type of crop is often planted between rows of another. China is the world's biggest producer of the crops shown below. Percentages indicate China's share in world production.



THE NEW YEAR

Every year, in late January or early February, Chinese people prepare to celebrate the New Year. They spring-clean their houses, put up red decorations to bring them luck, and give new clothes and toys to their children. The New Year festival itself lasts for several days. Every shop and office is closed, and people take to the streets, letting off firecrackers and joining in the displays of lion and dragon dances.